

Schools of Buddhism — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Canonical ownership controls conflicts. The primary sequence is exactly fourteen Buddhism-owned PYQs from 2018–2026. Three cross-owner comparisons are retained separately as Supporting S1–S3.

Directive and timed-answer framework

| Marks | Exact band | Recommended architecture |

| ---:|---:|---:|

| 10 | 150–200 words | definition → mechanism → evaluation |

| 15 | 250–300 words | thesis → distinctions → objection/reply → verdict |

| 20 | 340–400 words | conceptual derivation → detail → criticism → graded conclusion |

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Current canonical primary sequence

Verified wording and status. The fourteen numbered questions below are the complete Buddhism-primary sequence for 2018–2026. Wording and marks follow the verified ledgers exactly. Every model is independent learner practice, not an official UPSC key.

Ownership. Primary numbering is reserved for Buddhism-owned questions. Three cross-owner questions are preserved separately as Supporting S1–S3 and are not counted among the fourteen primary questions.

Word bands used. 10 marks: 150–200 words. 15 marks: 250–300 words. 20 marks: 340–400 words.

FOURTEEN PRIMARY BUDDHISM PYQS — COMPLETE SOLUTIONS

Primary PYQ 1 · 2018 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How do the Mādhyamika Buddhists apply the notion of Pratītyasamutpāda to establish their doctrine of Śūnyatā? Discuss.

Demand decoded. The hinge word is "apply". The examiner wants a derivation, not two definitions placed side by side. Show that emptiness is extracted from dependent origination, and protect the conclusion from nihilism.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

For Mādhyamika, dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) means that whatever arises does so only in dependence on causes, conditions, parts and conceptual designation. Nāgārjuna converts this causal principle into an ontological one in six steps.

To possess intrinsic nature (svabhāva) is to exist through oneself; what exists through itself does not await conditions; but everything conditioned arises in dependence on conditions; therefore nothing conditioned possesses intrinsic nature; to lack intrinsic nature is to be empty; therefore whatever is dependently arisen is empty (śūnya). Nāgārjuna accordingly identifies the dependently arisen with the empty.

Emptiness is therefore not non-being. A chariot, a flame or a person functions perfectly well while being undiscoverable as a self-grounded substance. The two truths secure this: at conventional truth (saṃvṛti-satya) persons, moral consequence and compassion operate; at ultimate truth (paramārtha-satya) no dharma has own-being. Even emptiness is empty, being itself a dependent designation rather than a hidden absolute.

The application is thus strict: dependence excludes independence, and emptiness names exactly that exclusion.

Why this earns marks. It gives the derivation as a numbered inference rather than as an assertion, defines svabhāva instead of leaving emptiness as a slogan, and closes the nihilism exit with the two truths and the emptiness of emptiness.

Primary PYQ 2 · 2018 · Q6(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Is it consistent for the Buddhists to admit the theory of Nairātmyavāda and the doctrine of Nirvāṇa simultaneously? Give reasons in favour of your answer.

Demand decoded. "Give reasons in favour" fixes the verdict direction: argue for consistency. But a bare defence scores less than a defence that first shows why the objection seems compelling and then dissolves it.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The objection has real force. If no permanent self exists, it seems there is no one to be bound, no one to practise and no one to be liberated; and if everything is momentary, nothing survives to enjoy liberation. Śaṅkara-type Advaita and Nyāya both press this.

The Buddhist reply begins by exposing a presupposition. The question "who attains nirvāṇa?" already assumes the substantial claimant whose removal is the liberation. Cessation of conditioned suffering is not a possession acquired by an owner; it is the extinction of attachment (rāga), aversion (dveṣa) and delusion (moha), and therefore the ceasing of the process that manufactures suffering.

Once this is seen, no permanent self (nairātmyavāda) is not an obstacle to liberation but its condition. Ignorance superimposes "I" and "mine" on the five aggregates; that appropriation generates craving, clinging and renewed becoming. Insight into no-self removes the cognitive basis of appropriation, and the chain loses its fuel. Momentariness supplies the complementary explanation: only a series of conditioned events can be interrupted by withdrawing a condition, whereas a permanent bondage would be permanent.

Continuity of practice is preserved by the causal continuum (santāna). The later liberated stream is neither numerically identical with nor wholly unrelated to the earlier bound stream, exactly as one lamp lights another. Theravāda classifications treat nibbāna as unconditioned (asaṃskṛta) without making it the state of an eternal self; Nāgārjuna adds that saṃsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms.

One pressure survives: the first-person claim "I am liberated" is explained only as a conventional index within the stream. That is a cost, not a contradiction — so the two doctrines are consistent, and mutually required.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection at full strength, answers by exposing a presupposition rather than by defending, shows that the doctrines are mutually supporting rather than merely compatible, and ends with a qualified verdict that matches the directive.

Primary PYQ 3 · 2019 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How do the Yogācāra Buddhists deny the existence of the external world? Discuss.

Demand decoded. "How" asks for arguments, not for a translation of vijñaptimātra. Three distinct arguments plus one sentence protecting the school from solipsism is a complete answer at this length.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Yogācāra advances representation-only (vijñaptimātra): what is given is cognition-as-presentation, not an independently established object. Three arguments support the denial and divide labour.

The dream argument removes realism's evidence: a dream supplies depth, objects and an apparent perceiver without any external correlate, so the mere fact that experience appears outer cannot prove an outer cause. The atom critique removes its coherence: partless atoms have no sides with which to combine, while atoms with parts are not ultimate, so the realist account of gross objects is unstable. The time-gap argument, taken from Sautrāntika and pressed further, removes its explanatory role: since object and cognition are momentary, the object has already ceased when its cognition arises, leaving only its form — so the inferred external cause does no work.

Order is then explained internally. Store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) carries karmic seeds (bīja) whose maturation produces regular, shared experience; the world is intersubjective because karmically co-conditioned, not because one ego invents it.

The denial is therefore of independent establishment, not of causal order.

Why this earns marks. It supplies three arguments with distinct functions instead of one analogy, names the store-consciousness mechanism that keeps the position from collapsing into solipsism, and states the thesis in its defensible form.

Primary PYQ 4 · 2019 · Q7(c) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: What is Pratītyasamutpāda? How do the Buddhists apply this concept to prove that everything is momentary?

Demand decoded. Two explicit demands: define, then derive. The derivation is where marks are won or lost, because dependence alone yields impermanence and not strict momentariness.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) is the principle that whatever arises, arises in dependence on causes and conditions, and ceases when those conditions cease: this being, that becomes; from the cessation of this, that ceases. Its primary subject-matter is the arising and cessation of suffering, and it supplies the causal grammar of the second and third Noble Truths.

The derivation of momentariness proceeds in two stages, and conflating them is the standard error.

Stage one is immediate. What depends on conditions cannot remain numerically identical through all times, because it alters as those conditions rise and fall. Therefore whatever is conditioned is impermanent (anitya).

Stage two requires an added premise from the Buddhist logicians: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect (sat = arthakriyā-samartha). A wholly permanent entity cannot satisfy this. If it produces its whole effect at once, nothing remains for later production — the simultaneity horn (yaugapadya). If it produces effects successively, it functions differently at different times, and what functions differently has changed — the succession horn (krama). Nyāya's escape, that it acts when auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) are present, is closed by the sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma: either the permanent thing already had the power, so the auxiliaries are idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, so the permanent thing is redundant. Hence yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.

Continuity is preserved, not denied: the causal series (santāna) with similarity (sādrśya) explains why a flame or a river looks like one thing.

Critically, Nyāya's counter-charge — that a series explains succession but not the ownership of memory and desert — retains force, so the derivation is powerful without being uncontested.

Why this earns marks. It separates the two stages of the derivation, names both horns and the dilemma that closes the realist escape, retains the continuity device, and ends with the residual objection rather than an unqualified claim.

Primary PYQ 5 · 2020 · Q6(a) · 20 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How is Kṣaṇikavāda a logical derivative of Pratītyasamutpāda in Buddhism? Explain.

Demand decoded. "Logical derivative" is the operative phrase: the examiner wants an inference reconstructed, with its premises exposed. "Explain" permits exposition but rewards the candidate who shows exactly what dependence does and does not by itself deliver.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

Dependent origination (pratītyasamutpāda) states that whatever arises does so in dependence on conditions and ceases when they cease. Momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda) states that whatever is real is momentary. The second is a derivative of the first, but the derivation has two stages and an added premise, and an answer that hides the premise misrepresents the logic.

Stage one: from dependence to impermanence. If a thing arises only when conditions cooperate, its being is indexed to those conditions. Conditions rise and fall; the thing alters with them; therefore it cannot remain numerically identical through all times. So whatever is conditioned is impermanent (anitya). This much is already contained in the three marks (trilakṣaṇa).

Stage two: from impermanence to strict momentariness. Impermanence permits long-lived changing things; momentariness does not. The extra premise is the Buddhist criterion of reality: to be real is to be capable of producing an effect, sat = arthakriyā-samartha. From it the logicians construct a dilemma against any permanent efficient cause. Either it produces its whole effect simultaneously, in which case nothing is left for later production (yaugapadya); or it produces successively, in which case it functions differently at different moments, and what functions differently is not wholly unchanged (krama). Nyāya replies that the permanent substance acts when auxiliary conditions (sahakārin) obtain; the sahakāri-anapekṣā dilemma closes this, since either the thing already possessed the power, making auxiliaries idle, or the auxiliaries supply it, making the permanent thing causally redundant. A second line adds that perishing needs no external destroyer: arising already contains ceasing. Therefore yat sat tat kṣaṇikam.

What is preserved. The doctrine is not annihilationism. Apparent persistence is explained by the causal series (santāna), whose successive members are similar enough (sādrśya) to be designated as one thing — the flame and the stream. Memory, moral consequence and rebirth are carried by the same series.

Verdict. The derivation is genuinely logical rather than merely historical, but it is conditional on the criterion of the real. Nyāya's most effective counter is therefore criterial rather than perceptual: it refuses to identify reality with causal efficacy, and it presses that a series cannot own memory or desert. Momentariness stands as the strongest Buddhist argument against substance, while remaining hostage to a premise its opponents deny.

Why this earns marks. It answers "logical derivative" by exhibiting the inference in two stages, exposes the hidden premise that most scripts suppress, closes the realist escape route by name, preserves continuity, and delivers a conditional verdict rather than a summary.

Primary PYQ 6 · 2020 · Q7(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How does Buddhism explain Self in terms of Pañcaskandhas? What is Liberation for Buddhism if there is no Soul?

Demand decoded. Two demands joined by a challenge. Enumerate and use the aggregates, then answer the challenge directly instead of restating no-self.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Buddhism replaces the question "what is the self?" with an exhaustive inventory. The person is analysed into five aggregates (pañca-skandha): form or material body (rūpa), feeling (vedanā), perception or recognition (saṃjñā), dispositions or formations (saṃskāra), and consciousness (vijñāna).

Each is examined and found impermanent; what is impermanent and appropriated is unsatisfactory; and what is impermanent and unsatisfactory is not fit to be regarded as "this is mine, this I am, this is my self". No sixth item is discovered behind or above them. "Self" is therefore a designation (prajñapti) made upon the aggregates, not a discovery among them. The chariot analogy of the Milinda-pañha makes the semantic point precisely: "chariot" is correct usage without naming an extra entity beyond parts in working arrangement.

The force of the argument depends entirely on the enumeration being exhaustive, which is why the Puggalavāda of the Vātsīputrīyas — a person neither identical with nor different from the aggregates — was rejected as a relapse into self-theory.

Liberation follows without a soul. Cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) is the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, and thereby the ceasing of the process that produces suffering. Ignorance superimposes ownership on the aggregate-stream; that appropriation generates craving and renewed becoming; insight into no-self withdraws the appropriation and the process runs down. Practice is carried by the causal series (saṁtāna), and the practitioner is the conventional person, which is all that discipline requires.

The residual difficulty is that a series explains succession more easily than ownership; Buddhism answers by treating ownership as a conventional designation rather than an ultimate fact.

Why this earns marks. It enumerates the aggregates and then uses them as an argument, supplies the semantic reading of the chariot, cites the rejected internal foil as evidence of principled cost, and answers the liberation challenge by redescribing liberation rather than by denying the difficulty.

Primary PYQ 7 · 2021 · Q5(d) · 10 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Distinguish between pudgala-nairātmyavāda and dharma-nairātmyavāda with reference to Buddhist Philosophy.

Demand decoded. "Distinguish" requires criteria, not two paragraphs. Fix the axes — what is denied, by whom, and with what consequence — and the answer writes itself.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Both are forms of no-self, differing in scope.

Personal no-self (pudgala-nairātmya) denies a permanent, independent person (pudgala) behind experience. The person is a designation on the five aggregates, and no owner is found among or behind them. This is the minimum thesis shared across Buddhist traditions, and it is what the chariot analogy establishes.

Phenomenon no-self (dharma-nairātmya) extends the same analysis to the constituent factors themselves, denying that any dharma possesses intrinsic nature (svabhāva).

The difference is therefore between the owner and the inventory on which the owner was denied. Early Buddhism and the realist Abhidharma schools accept the first while treating dharmas as ultimately real; Vaibhāṣika and Sautrāntika are precisely such positions. Mahāyāna, and Mādhyamika above all, presses the second, which is why dependence yields emptiness there but conditioned realism in the earlier schools.

The distinction is one of philosophical scope, not of institutional affiliation, and it should not be converted into a contrast between Theravāda and Mahāyāna as wholes.

Why this earns marks. It fixes a single criterion of distinction, attaches each thesis to the schools that stress it, connects the difference to the divergent conclusions drawn from dependent origination, and adds the qualification that blocks the standard mislabelling.

Primary PYQ 8 · 2021 · Q7(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: If everything is momentary then how do the Buddhists explain the problem of memory and personal identity? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. "Critically discuss" makes the residual objection compulsory. State the Nyāya case at full strength, give the Buddhist devices by name, and close with an honest verdict.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The Nyāya objection, in the line of Vātsyāyana, Uddyotakara and Udayana, is sharp. If every mental state perishes instantly, the state that remembers is not the state that experienced, so there is no rememberer. Recognition (pratyabhijñā) — "this is that same jar", "I am the one who saw it" — appears to disclose identity through time, and moral desert seems to require that the doer be the enjoyer.

Buddhism answers with three named devices. The causal continuum (santāna) locates memory within one stream: the earlier experience conditions a later cognition that presents itself as recollection, so no permanent subject is required. Similarity (sādrśya) explains recognition: a later causal phase resembling an earlier one is conventionally taken as numerically the same, which is why the flame and the river look like single things. Reconnection (pratisandhāna) extends continuity across the discontinuities of sleep and death, and Yogācāra supplements it with store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) carrying seeds (bīja), a conditioned transforming stream rather than a disguised self.

The resulting position is deliberately a middle: the later subject is neither strictly the same as nor wholly other than the earlier one (na sa eva na cānyaḥ). Strict identity would be eternalism; strict difference would destroy responsibility.

Critically, the reply is strong against the demand for a carrier and weak against the demand for a subject. Nyāya's residual force is that a series may explain why a memory occurs without explaining how it is owned, and Advaita presses further that the unity of experience seems to need a witness.

The defensible verdict is that Buddhism explains personal identity successfully as continuity, while conceding that ownership is a conventional designation rather than an ultimate fact.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection with named opponents, answers with three distinct technical devices rather than one, gives the middle formula in its canonical phrasing, and separates what the reply achieves from what it concedes.

Primary PYQ 9 · 2022 · Q6(a) · 20 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How compatible is Buddhist theory of momentariness with their theory of Karma? In this regard how do Buddhists respond to objections raised by their opponents? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. Three demands: assess compatibility, report the responses, and criticise. The second demand requires named opponents; the third requires a verdict that is graded rather than triumphant.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

The tension is genuine. Momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda) holds that whatever is real is momentary; action and moral consequence (karma) requires that the fruit of an act reach the one who performed it. If the agent perishes with the act, the recipient appears to be someone else, and moral desert collapses.

The Buddhist position. Buddhism refuses the disjunction on which the objection rests. The relation between the acting stage and the receiving stage is neither identity nor utter difference — na sa eva na cānyaḥ. Strict identity would reinstate the eternal self (ātman) already denied; strict difference would make reward and punishment fall on a stranger. What holds them together is the causal

continuum (santāna): the fruit is received by the stream that the earlier stage conditioned. The illustration is one lamp lighting another — not the same flame, not an unrelated one. Rebirth is relinking (pratisandhāna) of one series to another rather than transmigration, so nothing crosses over. Moral quality itself is located in intention (cetanā), a formation among the aggregates. Yogācāra adds store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) carrying seeds (bīja) to explain why latent potential survives long intervals.

Opponents and responses. Nyāya, in the Vātsyāyana–Uddyotakara–Udayana line, argues from recognition, memory and desert to an enduring self; the Buddhist replies with the series and with similarity (sādṛśya), which explains why a later similar phase is taken as the same. Kumāriḷa Bhaṭṭa argues that duty and cognition require a persisting subject; Dignāga and Dharmakīrti reply that the subject is a constructed unity imposed on a stream of momentary cognitions. Śaṅkara-type Advaita argues that bondage and release cannot belong to no one; the two-truths reply is that persons and practice are valid designations at conventional truth while nothing has intrinsic nature at ultimate truth.

Critical verdict. The compatibility is real but asymmetric. Buddhism explains succession — why this fruit follows that act — with unusual precision, and protects impermanence and responsibility simultaneously. What it explains less convincingly is ownership: causal continuity shows why a later stage inherits, but not obviously why it deserves. The Buddhist rejoinder, that desert is a conventional notion tracking causal continuity and that the demand for ultimate desert presupposes an ultimate subject, is coherent. The doctrines are therefore compatible, at the price of relocating moral desert to conventional truth.

Why this earns marks. It states the tension precisely, resolves it through the canonical middle formula, names three distinct opponents with their specific arguments and the specific Buddhist replies, adds intention as the locus of moral quality, and closes with a graded verdict that identifies exactly what is and is not secured.

Primary PYQ 10 · 2022 · Q7(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Explain Buddhist concept of Triratna and their internal relation. Critically examine the consistency of Triratnas with the Buddhist concept of No-soul (Nairātmyavāda).

Demand decoded. Two tasks, and the first is usually done badly. "Internal relation" is not a list of three items; it asks how the three depend on one another.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The Three Jewels (Triratna) are the Buddha, the Dharma and the Saṅgha, the threefold refuge of the Buddhist practitioner.

Internal relation. They form a functional triad rather than three parallel objects of devotion. The Buddha is the one who discovered and demonstrated the path; the Dharma is the teaching and the truth it states, and is what actually liberates; the Saṅgha is the community that preserves, transmits and exemplifies the teaching. The dependence therefore runs in two directions. In order of origin it is Buddha → Dharma → Saṅgha, since the teaching derives from the awakening and the community from the teaching. In order of access it is Saṅgha → Dharma → Buddha, since a present-day practitioner reaches the teaching through the community that preserved it. What liberates is identified as the Dharma, which is why refuge is not devotion to a person.

Consistency with no-self. The objection is immediate: if there is no self, who takes refuge? Buddhism answers that the refuge-taker is the conventional person, a designated person (prajñapti-puruṣa) upon the five aggregates, not an ultimately real soul. That is all refuge requires, because what is needed is a causal series capable of being conditioned by instruction — and intention and dispositions are themselves aggregates.

Far from conflicting, the two doctrines cohere: no-self purifies refuge of ego-metaphysics. Refuge is not the surrender of a soul to a saviour but the reorientation of a stream by a teaching.

Critically, the reply relocates the practitioner to conventional truth, so the Advaitic pressure about the unity of the practising subject remains — a cost, not an inconsistency.

Why this earns marks. It answers "internal relation" with two directions of dependence rather than a list, identifies the Dharma as the liberating member, answers the consistency challenge with the technical term for the conventional person, and concedes the surviving pressure without conceding the charge.

Primary PYQ 11 · 2023 · Q8(a) · 20 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: "Ignorance of dependent origination is suffering while its knowledge is cessation of suffering." Present an account of Buddhist soteriology in the light of above statement.

Demand decoded. A quotation-anchored question. The examiner is testing whether the candidate can show that ignorance is causally productive rather than merely absent knowledge, and can then present the whole path as the removal of that cause.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

The quoted statement is not an epistemic slogan but a causal thesis: misreading how things exist is itself the engine of suffering, and correcting the misreading dismantles it.

Why ignorance is productive. Ignorance (*avidyā*) is not blankness. It is the active misconstrual of conditioned processes as stable possessions — treating what is dependently arisen as though it had intrinsic nature and belonged to an owner. That misconstrual generates appropriation: what is taken as "mine" is defended, pursued and mourned. This is why ignorance heads the twelve links (*dvādaśa-nidāna*), conditioning formations, consciousness, name-and-form, the six sense-bases, contact, feeling, craving, clinging, becoming, birth, and ageing-and-death.

Where the chain can be cut. Feeling (*vedanā*) arises unavoidably from contact; craving (*tṛṣṇā*) does not arise unavoidably from feeling. That gap is the operative joint, and the Noble Eightfold Path (*āryāṣṭāṅgamārga*) is built to work on it. Grouped under three trainings, wisdom (right view, right intention) attacks ignorance directly, ethical discipline (right speech, action, livelihood) removes the conduct that continually renews craving, and meditative discipline (right effort, mindfulness, concentration) stabilises the attention in which feeling is prevented from hardening into demand.

Why cessation follows. The reverse order (*pratiloma*) of the chain states that with the cessation of ignorance, formations cease, and so on to the cessation of ageing-and-death. Cessation is therefore not an additional event to be hoped for; it is entailed by removing a condition in a dependently arisen series. This converts the third Noble Truth from an assertion into a consequence, and it is exactly what the quoted sentence claims.

What liberation is. Cessation of conditioned suffering (*nirvāṇa*) is the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion. Since the self was never found, nothing is annihilated; the process of grasping simply ceases. The practitioner is the conventional person, and continuity of practice is carried by the causal series (*santāna*), not by a soul.

Critical assessment. The soteriology is unusually tight: diagnosis, cause, cessation and therapy are one argument, and the metaphysics of impermanence and no-self are entailments of the therapeutic claim rather than additions to it. Its contested point is whether knowledge alone, however transformative, can uproot deeply conditioned craving; the tradition answers by making insight inseparable from conduct and attention, which is why the path has eight factors and not one.

Why this earns marks. It converts the quotation into a causal claim and defends it, uses the twelve links and the reverse order to make cessation an entailment, maps the eightfold path onto the exact joint it targets, and finishes with a critical point that arises from the doctrine rather than from outside it.

Primary PYQ 12 · 2024 · Q6(b) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How do the two schools of Buddhism arrive at two opposed conclusions, namely "everything is void" and "everything is real" from the same doctrine of *Pratītyasamutpāda*? Answer with arguments.

Demand decoded. "Answer with arguments" forbids a descriptive contrast. The task is to show how one premise supports two conclusions, which means locating the extra premise on which the schools differ.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

Both conclusions start from dependent origination (*pratītyasamutpāda*): whatever arises does so in dependence on conditions. They diverge because they apply different criteria of the ultimately real to that shared premise.

"Everything is void" — *Mādhyamika*. To possess intrinsic nature (*svabhāva*) is to exist through oneself; what exists through itself does not await conditions; everything conditioned awaits conditions; therefore nothing conditioned has intrinsic nature; to lack intrinsic nature is to be empty. *Nāgārjuna* accordingly identifies the dependently arisen with the empty (*śūnya*). The criterion of ultimacy here is independence, and dependence excludes it.

"Everything is real" — *Vaiśiṣṭika* and *Sautrāntika*. These schools accept the same causal premise and infer that precisely because things arise causally, they are real as conditioned entities. *Vaiśiṣṭika* holds direct realism about dharmas and affirms *sarvam asti*, that dharmas of the three times have some mode of existence; *Sautrāntika* restricts full existence to the present and holds that external objects are inferred from the form (*ākāra*) borne by cognition. The criterion of ultimacy here is causal efficacy, and dependence supplies it.

Why this is not a contradiction. The two answer different questions. "Everything is void" answers does anything possess intrinsic nature? "Everything is real" answers is anything causally efficacious? The realists deny permanence, not causal reality; the *Mādhyamika* denies intrinsic nature, not conventional functioning. The two truths make this explicit: at conventional truth things function; at ultimate truth none has own-being.

The genuine dispute is therefore not verbal but criterial — whether causal efficacy is sufficient for ultimate status, or whether independence is required.

Why this earns marks. It isolates the shared premise, exhibits both derivations as arguments, names the two realist schools separately with their distinguishing theses, and resolves the apparent contradiction by identifying the divergent criterion instead of asserting that the schools simply disagree.

Primary PYQ 13 · 2025 · Q8(c) · 15 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Is Buddhist notion of Nirvāṇa in consonance with their conception of Kṣaṇikavāda (momentariness) and Nairātmyavāda (no-soul theory)? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. A three-way consistency question with "critically discuss". It differs from the 2018 fifteen-marker by expressly adding momentariness, so the answer must show what momentariness specifically contributes rather than treating it as a synonym for no-self.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The three doctrines are not merely compatible; each is required by the others.

What no-self contributes. Cessation of conditioned suffering (nirvāṇa) is the extinction of attachment, aversion and delusion, not a possession acquired by an owner. The objection "who attains?" therefore presupposes the very claimant whose removal constitutes the attainment. No permanent self (nairātmyavāda) removes the false claimant, and in doing so removes the appropriation that generated craving in the first place.

What momentariness contributes, distinctly. It is not a restatement of no-self. It supplies the positive explanation of possibility: only a series of conditioned events can be interrupted by withdrawing a condition. A permanent bondage, or a permanent defilement inhering in a permanent substance, could not be removed at all. Momentariness thus underwrites the third Noble Truth, while no-self underwrites the diagnosis of what must be given up.

How practice is carried. Continuity is supplied by the causal series (saṁtāna), the later liberated stream being neither identical with nor unrelated to the earlier bound stream. Theravāda classifications treat nibbāna as unconditioned (asaṁskṛta) — outside the dependent series, not a substance with properties. Nāgārjuna adds that saṁsāra and nirvāṇa are not two independent realms; the difference lies in how dependent reality is grasped.

Critically. Two costs remain. The first-person claim "I am liberated" is explained only as a conventional index within the stream, and the Advaitin presses that the unity of experience still requires a witness. Buddhism answers by refusal rather than by explanation, on the ground that a witness would be one more reification.

The verdict is consonance, purchased by relocating the liberated subject to conventional truth.

Why this earns marks. It differentiates the distinct contributions of no-self and momentariness instead of treating them as one point, handles the unconditioned classification without error, cites Nāgārjuna's non-duality of saṁsāra and nirvāṇa, and states the surviving Advaitic pressure as a cost rather than a refutation.

Primary PYQ 14 · 2026 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Buddhism · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How does the Buddhist theory of momentariness problematize the issue of human action and responsibility? Critically discuss.

Demand decoded. Explain why strict momentariness creates an agency problem, then distinguish numerical identity from causally connected responsibility and assess the residual objection.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Momentariness creates an apparent gap between action and responsibility. If the agent who acts perishes immediately, the later recipient of karmic consequence is not numerically the same subject. A permanent soul cannot solve the problem within Buddhism because no-self denies such a substance. The Buddhist reply replaces identity with causal continuity. An intentional act conditions the succeeding stream of psycho-physical events; later stages inherit dispositions and consequences from earlier stages through the causal continuum, or saṁtāna. The fruit therefore occurs neither in an utterly identical self nor in an unrelated being: the later phase is "neither the same nor another." Intention, cetanā, gives action its moral quality, while continuity links that quality to later experience. Yogācāra's store-consciousness and seeds offer one school-specific elaboration, not a universal substantial carrier. The account avoids fatalism because conditioned sequences can be redirected by insight and practice. Yet a realist objection remains: causal connectedness may explain transmission without fully explaining ownership or desert. Buddhism answers that conventional personal

identity is sufficient for responsibility, while ultimate analysis finds only dependent events. Thus momentariness problematizes, but need not abolish, agency.

SUPPORTING CROSS-TOPIC PYQS — OUTSIDE PRIMARY NUMBERING

Supporting cross-topic PYQ S1 · 2018 · Q5(d) · 10 marks · Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika-primary / Buddhism-supporting · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: How do the Buddhists and the Nyāya philosophers explain our knowledge of 'the absence of the jar on the table'? Answer in detail.

Routing note: primary ownership rests with Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika; it is solved here because the Buddhist half is owned by this topic and is the half most often written thinly.

Demand decoded. A two-sided comparative question. Give each side's account of how the cognition arises, not merely its ontology of absence.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Nyāya. Absence (*abhāva*) is admitted as a real category. In "there is no jar on the table", the table is the locus (*anuyogin*) and the jar is the counterpositive (*pratiyogin*) whose absence qualifies that locus, so absence-cognition has structured intentional content rather than blankness. No independent means of knowledge called non-cognition is required: under suitable conditions the same perceptual situation that presents the empty locus presents jar-absence through the qualifier–qualified relation (*viśeṣaṇa-viśeṣya-bhāva*). The conditions are that the jar would have been perceptible if present, that the locus is available, and that the senses are unobstructed. Where the missing item is itself inferential, its absence may be inferentially established.

Buddhists. No separately existing negative entity is admitted. The judgement is explained by perception of the positive locus together with non-apprehension of the jar, and is then handled conceptually — by exclusion (*apoha*) and by inference, since the Buddhist epistemologists recognise only perception and inference and reduce non-apprehension to them.

The contrast is thus categorial: Nyāya adds absence to the world; Buddhism adds it only to the conceptual construction of the world.

Why this earns marks. It gives both sides the technical vocabulary their own systems use, explains the mechanism of the cognition rather than only the ontology, and closes with a single sentence that names the precise point of disagreement.

Supporting cross-topic PYQ S2 · 2024 · Q6(a) · 20 marks · Cārvāka-primary / Buddhism-supporting · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Differentiate between the Cārvākas' refutation of self as a transcendental category and the Buddhist rejection of *ātmā*.

Routing note: primary ownership rests with Cārvāka; it is solved here because the Buddhist half of the differentiation is owned by this topic and carries most of the analytical weight.

Demand decoded. "Differentiate" demands fixed axes. The trap is to write two summaries; the reward is for showing that a shared conclusion is reached by opposite routes and issues in opposite consequences.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

Both schools deny an eternal self (*ātman*), and there the agreement ends. They differ in method, in what replaces the self, and in what the denial costs.

Method. Cārvāka argues from a restriction of knowledge. Accepting perception as the sole reliable means, and refusing inference independent standing, it holds that no transcendental self is ever perceived; what is observed is a living body in which awareness appears. The denial is therefore epistemically driven and reductive. Buddhism argues from an exhaustive analysis. The person is divided into five aggregates (*pañca-skandha*) — form, feeling, perception, formations, consciousness — each found impermanent, unsatisfactory when grasped and not fit to be owned; and no sixth item is discovered. The denial is therefore analytically driven, and Buddhism accepts inference as one of its two means of valid knowledge.

What replaces the self. For Cārvāka the replacement is the body: consciousness is treated as arising from the organised material elements, as intoxicating power arises from ingredients that individually lack it. For Buddhism the replacement is a process: the person is a designation (*prajñapti*) on a causal series (*santāna*), illustrated by the chariot analogy of the *Milinda-pañha*. Buddhism explicitly refuses the materialist reduction, since consciousness is one aggregate conditioned by others rather than a by-product of body alone.

Consequences. This is where the differentiation earns its marks. Cārvāka's denial abolishes rebirth, moral consequence and liberation together; ethics becomes prudential and the goal becomes worldly well-being. Buddhism's denial is designed precisely to preserve rebirth, moral consequence and liberation without a bearer: the fruit falls on the stream that the acting stage conditioned, on the formula that the later stage is neither the same nor another (na sa eva na cānyah), with moral quality located in intention (cetanā).

Assessment. Cārvāka's position is economical and immune to the charge of speculative surplus, but it purchases economy by rejecting inference, which its rivals argue is self-defeating. Buddhism's position is more demanding, since it must explain memory, recognition and desert without an owner, and Nyāya's charge that a series cannot own what it transmits retains force.

The differentiation is therefore not one of degree. Cārvāka rejects the self to shrink the world to what perception delivers; Buddhism rejects it to redescribe the world as process while keeping everything the self was invoked to explain.

Why this earns marks. It uses three fixed axes rather than two summaries, names the technical devices on each side, identifies the decisive contrast in consequences rather than in doctrine alone, and ends with a balanced assessment that gives each position its characteristic strength and cost.

Supporting cross-topic PYQ S3 · 2025 · Q5(b) · 10 marks · Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika-primary / Buddhism-supporting · fully solved

Question, exact verified wording: Present an exposition of the debate between Naiyāyikas and Buddhists with reference to the notion of Pramāṇa and Pramāṇaphala.

Routing note: primary ownership rests with Nyāya–Vaiśeṣika; it is solved here because the Buddhist side of the debate is owned by this topic through the Dignāga–Dharmakīrti material.

Demand decoded. "Exposition of the debate" requires both positions and the reason they differ. The reason is metaphysical, and saying so is what lifts the answer above a definitional contrast.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

Nyāya. The knower (pramātr), the means of valid knowledge (pramāṇa), the object (prameya) and the resulting true cognition (pramā or pramāṇaphala) are analytically distinct factors in a realist cognitive episode. The operative instrument or causal complex is the pramāṇa; true cognition is its fruit. Means and result are therefore different.

Buddhists. Dignāga tightens the relation so that the instrument of knowledge and its result are not ultimately different. The resultant cognition — the determination of the object together with the self-awareness of cognition (svasamvedana) — is non-different from the cognitive event that functions as pramāṇa. The analysis into instrument (karaṇa) and result (phala) is a conceptual overlay on a single momentary cognition.

Why they differ. The disagreement is downstream of metaphysics. Nyāya has an enduring knower who uses a real instrument on a real object; Buddhism, having denied the permanent self and admitted only momentary events, has no bearer to hold the fourfold apparatus apart. Nyāya is instrumentally realist; Buddhist epistemology is cognition-centred.

Why this earns marks. It presents both positions in their own vocabulary, identifies the Buddhist thesis precisely as non-difference rather than as identity, and explains the disagreement by tracing it to the dispute over the self instead of leaving it as a clash of definitions.

Original coverage-driven timed practice

The formal workbook's six original models are preserved verbatim below. They supply coverage-driven 10-, 15- and 20-mark practice beyond the fourteen primary and three supporting PYQs.

ORIGINAL SOLVED MAINS PRACTICE — SIX MODELS

These six questions are original practice items written in UPSC style. They are not previous-year questions and are not represented as such.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain the two senses of the Middle Path (madhyamā pratipad) in Buddhism. Why is the doctrinal sense indispensable to the practical one?

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

The Middle Path operates in two registers.

Practically, it rejects sensual indulgence and self-mortification, replacing both with the Noble Eightfold Path (āryāṣṭāṅgamārga) grouped under wisdom (right view, right intention), ethical discipline (right speech, action, livelihood) and meditative discipline (right effort, mindfulness, concentration). The rejection is diagnostic: indulgence feeds craving, while mortification exhausts the practitioner without touching it.

Doctrinally, it rejects eternalism (śāśvatavāda) and annihilationism (ucchedavāda), replacing both with dependent origination and conditioned continuity.

The doctrinal sense is indispensable because the practical path is unintelligible without it. If a permanent self existed, training could not transform it, and the third Noble Truth would fail. If nothing continued, discipline could accumulate no result, and the fourth would fail. Only conditioned continuity — change without a permanent bearer, and continuity without annihilation — makes a path both necessary and effective.

Both senses share one logic: Buddhism denies the hidden assumption common to each pair of extremes rather than choosing between them.

Why this earns marks. It gives both senses with their positive content, then answers the "why" with a specific structural dependence rather than a general remark about coherence.

Original 2 · 10 marks

Question: "Buddhist epistemology is not a shortened Nyāya list." Examine this claim with reference to the two means of valid knowledge and the exclusion theory of meaning.

Model answer (10 marks, 150–200 words).

The claim is correct, and the reason is structural rather than numerical.

Dignāga and Dharmakīrti admit two means of valid knowledge because they hold that the number of means is fixed by the number of object-types. There are exactly two: the unique particular (svalakṣaṇa), which is momentary, causally efficient and ineffable, grasped by non-conceptual perception; and the constructed general character (sāmānyalakṣaṇa), grasped by inference. Comparison, postulation, non-apprehension and testimony are reduced to these, not omitted from a list.

The exclusion theory (apoha) confirms the point. Since only unique particulars are ultimately real, a general term cannot denote a real universal; "cow" functions as "not-non-cow", generality being constructed negatively upon shared causal capacity.

Both theses follow from momentariness and no-self, which is also why the instrument of knowledge is held to be non-different from its result. A shortened Nyāya list would still contain an enduring knower and real universals; Buddhist epistemology contains neither.

Why this earns marks. It refutes the claim by exhibiting a different principle of individuation, links two doctrines to the same metaphysical source, and names the consequence for pramāṇaphala.

Original 3 · 15 marks

Question: Analyse the four schools of Buddhism as an argumentative escalation rather than as a classification. What does each successive position gain and lose?

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The fourfold matrix is a philosophical doxography, and its explanatory value lies in the fact that each position is generated by an objection the previous one cannot absorb.

Vaibhāṣika holds direct realism about external dharmas and affirms sarvaṃ asti, that dharmas of past, present and future have some mode of existence. It gains a genuine object for every cognition and a real relation between a past act and its future fruit. It loses ontological economy and strains momentariness, since extending existence across the three times sits awkwardly with strict one-moment duration.

Sautrāntika answers by restricting full existence to the present. Since the object-moment has ceased when its cognition arises, cognition bears only the object's form (ākāra), from which the external object is inferred. It gains consistency with momentariness. It loses direct access, and now owes an account of why the inferred cause should correspond to the form it produces.

Yogācāra presses exactly there: if all that is ever given is the form, the external object performs no explanatory work. Representation-only (vijñaptimātra) gains economy, and explains order through store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) and seeds (bīja). It loses the easy explanation of intersubjective agreement, which must now be derived from shared karmic conditioning, and it exposes consciousness itself to the charge of reification.

Mādhymika presses that charge: even consciousness lacks intrinsic nature. Emptiness gains complete freedom from reification, including the emptiness of emptiness. It loses any positive ultimate, and must defend a non-implicative negation (prasajya-pratiśedha) against the objection that denying all four corners either says nothing or refutes itself.

Read as an escalation, the four schools display one method — remove whatever the analysis shows to be unnecessary — applied with increasing severity.

Why this earns marks. It supplies the objection that drives each transition, states a specific gain and a specific cost for every school, and ends with the methodological unity that makes the sequence an argument rather than a list.

Original 4 · 15 marks

Question: "The doctrine of two truths is what separates emptiness from nihilism." Critically examine, with reference to the four-cornered analysis.

Model answer (15 marks, 250–300 words).

The claim is substantially correct, though it needs a supplement.

The problem. The four-cornered analysis (catuṣkoṭi) sets out four alternatives — it is, it is not, it both is and is not, it neither is nor is not — and Nāgārjuna denies all four. To a realist this looks like the abolition of every position, hence nihilism, and the further charge that the denial is itself a thesis, so the claim to have no thesis (pratijñā) is self-refuting.

The first defence is the negation type. Madhyamaka negation is non-implicative (prasajya-pratiśedha) rather than implicative (paryudāsa-pratiśedha), and it is scoped: the four corners are denied of things taken as possessing intrinsic nature (svabhāva). Denying them therefore withdraws a malformed question rather than asserting four incompatible propositions, and no fifth positive thesis is installed. Nāgārjuna's supplement is that his own words are empty too, so they generate no ontological commitment; empty utterance cures empty reification as one magically created figure may counteract another (nirmitaka).

The second defence is the two truths, and this is what the claim identifies. At conventional truth (saṃvṛti-satya), persons, causation, moral consequence, compassion and the path all function; at ultimate truth (paramārtha-satya), nothing possesses own-being. Conventional truth is not falsehood but the operative domain of Buddhist practice. Without it, the fourfold denial would indeed leave nothing standing.

Critically, the two truths are necessary but not sufficient: the negation nuance must also be stated, or the doctrine still looks self-refuting. And whether a non-implicative negation can be sustained without covertly functioning as a thesis remains disputed, as the internal Prāsaṅgika–Svātantrika division shows.

The accurate verdict is that the two truths block nihilism, while the scoped negation blocks self-refutation, and emptiness needs both.

Why this earns marks. It states the objection in both its forms, distinguishes two distinct defences and assigns each to the charge it answers, and refines the quoted claim instead of simply endorsing it.

Original 5 · 20 marks

Question: Evaluate the claim that Buddhism preserves everything the self was invoked to explain, while dispensing with the self itself.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

The claim states Buddhism's ambition accurately. The question is whether the ambition is achieved, and the honest answer is: largely, but not entirely.

What the self was invoked to explain. In the realist systems, an enduring self (ātman) accounts for four things: continuity through time, memory and recognition, the justice of moral consequence, and the unity of one experiencing life.

How Buddhism replaces each. Continuity is supplied by the causal series (santāna), whose successive members are similar enough (sādrśya) to be designated as one thing — the flame and the river. Memory is a later cognition conditioned by an earlier experience within the same stream, extended across discontinuities by reconnection (pratisandhāna) and, in Yogācāra, by store-consciousness (ālaya-vijñāna) carrying seeds (bīja). Moral consequence is preserved by the formula that the later stage is neither the same nor another (na sa eva na cānyaḥ), with moral quality located in intention (cetanā), itself an aggregate. Practice and refuge are preserved by the conventional person (prajñapti-puruṣa).

Where the replacement succeeds. It succeeds against the demand for a carrier. Every function the realist assigned to a substance is discharged by a causal relation, and the resulting system is more economical: it explains bondage and release with the same apparatus, since only a conditioned series can be interrupted by removing a condition.

Where it is pressed hardest. Two functions resist. First, ownership: Nyāya, in the Vātsyāyana–Uddyotakara–Udayana line, argues that a series may explain why a memory occurs without explaining whose memory it is, and that desert requires more than inheritance. Second, unity: Śaṅkara-type Advaita argues that the presentation of a manifold as one field requires a self-luminous witness, and that denying the self presupposes it. Buddhism answers the first by treating ownership as a conventional designation and the second by refusing the witness as one more reification — coherent answers that relocate rather than discharge the demand.

Verdict. The claim holds for continuity, memory-transmission, karmic inheritance and practice, and holds only at the conventional level for ownership and unity. Buddhism therefore dispenses with the self successfully as an explanatory posit while conceding that some of the work it did survives as convention rather than as ultimate fact — which is why the dispute with Nyāya and Advaita has never been settled by either side.

Why this earns marks. It converts an evaluative claim into a checklist of four explanatory functions, supplies the specific Buddhist replacement for each with technical terms, separates successes from residues, names the opponents who press the residues, and delivers a differentiated rather than a global verdict.

Original 6 · 20 marks

Question: Compare the Buddhist and Jaina responses to the problem of change and permanence, and assess which secures the reality of the world at lower philosophical cost.

Model answer (20 marks, 340–400 words).

Both are non-Vedic renouncer traditions, both deny a creator, and both must explain how a thing can change and still be spoken of as the same. Their solutions are opposites.

The Jaina solution. The real (sat) possesses origination (utpāda), decay (vyaya) and persistence (dhrauvya) together. Permanence belongs to substance (dravya) and change to modes (paryāya), so the gold persists while bracelet gives way to ring. Since the real has innumerable aspects, cognition is standpoint-relative (naya) and assertion carries the operator syāt, generating the sevenfold predication. Reality is many-sided (anekāntavāda), and the soul (jīva) is a real conscious substance obscured by action-matter.

The Buddhist solution: deny the persisting substance altogether. Whatever is conditioned is impermanent, and the criterion of the real as causally efficient (sat = arthakriyā-samartha) radicalises this into momentariness (kṣaṇikavāda), since a permanent entity can produce its effect neither all at once (yauḡapadya) nor successively (krama) without ceasing to be permanent. Apparent persistence is a causal series (santāna) of sufficiently similar moments; the person is a designation on five aggregates; no soul is admitted.

The costs, weighed. Jainism secures the world cheaply in ontology and expensively in logic. Nothing needs to be re-described: things really persist and really change. But predication must be permanently qualified, the schema of assertion becomes sevenfold, and the system must carry six substances, innumerable souls and material action-matter. Buddhism secures the world cheaply in logic and expensively in re-description. Assertion stays ordinary and the ontology is austere — momentary causally efficient events — but almost every ordinary notion must be relocated to conventional truth: the same thing, the same person, the rememberer, the deserver.

Assessment. If "reality of the world" means the truth of ordinary claims taken at face value, Jainism secures it at lower cost, because it never demotes them. If it means an ontology free of unexplained composites and unverifiable substances, Buddhism secures it at lower cost, because it posits less. The decisive contrast is methodological: Jainism qualifies the sentence to save the world; Buddhism qualifies the world to save the sentence.

The standard error must be avoided: Jainism affirms the soul emphatically, and only Buddhism denies it.

Why this earns marks. It states both solutions in their own technical vocabulary, converts "cost" into two explicit currencies rather than leaving it vague, delivers a conditional verdict that depends on how the question is read, and closes by disarming the comparison error that examiners most often penalise.

Major-doctrine answer spine

| Doctrine | Mandatory distinctions | Best critical move |

|---|---|---|

| Dependent origination | conditionality, twelve links, forward/reverse reading | dependence is not a simple first-to-last linear cause |

| Momentariness | causal efficacy, simultaneity/succession horns | distinguish impermanence from strict one-moment duration |

| No-self and continuity | five aggregates, santāna, similarity, reconnection | preserve responsibility without a substantial soul |

| Vaibhāṣika/Sautrāntika | direct realism versus representational inference | do not collapse historical layers |

| Yogācāra/Vijñānavāda | representation-only, three natures, store-consciousness | reject crude private subjective idealism |

| Mādhyamaka/Śūnyavāda | dependent origination, svabhāva, two truths | emptiness is not nihilism |

| Pramāṇa and apoha | perception, inference, exclusion | locate later epistemic debates without homogenising schools |

| Nirvāṇa | cessation, no-self, conventional person | explain liberation without importing an eternal subject |